



Three Wolf Moon t-shirt
Joke reviews about the product make its sale shoot up 2,300%



Chrome 2
Stable version released with improved speed, full screen mode, and auto-fill



MagCloud Beta
A service by HP, it is like the YouTube of online magazine publishing

You can even add new courses and assignments since these buttons are available on most pages. Notifications can be configured in the preferences, but SMS only works with US carriers.

Spotify

Spotify is relatively the latest music streaming service to hit cyberspace; and is making quite a few waves. Within a few months of launch the service has crossed more than half a million users, albeit it being available only on invitation basis in a handful of European countries such as Germany, Britain, France, Italy, Spain, Finland and Sweden. So what exactly is Spotify? How does it work and what's so great about it? It's essentially a tiny streaming service for PC or Mac. After creating an account, you simply type the name of the track or album you want and within five seconds you can listen to the music you asked for. Practically, no song is ever far away from you. Services such as **Last.fm** on the other hand only give you similar songs to the one you asked for. Besides, Spotify's repertoire of music quite vast – tipping the scales at around 8 million songs. What is more unique about this service is that it's free and completely legal. This due to Spotify's deals in place with the four major record labels of the world and not to mention the thousands of independent labels it has on its rolls. What's unfolding is probably the last leg of the battle between the

music industry and music piracy.

Some online blogs even likened Spotify to a lemonade stall run by the music industry that's giving out free lemonade. Well of course it's not all free. There is a premium paid version that plays tracks without ads. Otherwise listeners have to bear ads after about eight or nine tracks. The application itself is extremely easy to use. Its got fields such as recommendations and top artists, and top charts. In short, the whole works. No wonder regional and invitation restrictions haven't stopped anyone from using it. There are several reports of invitations being hawked at **inviteshare.com** and lots of users accessing it through proxy servers that mask the user's location. The service works on a unique hybrid p2p system that streams data from its own servers as well as other listeners.

Book marking

Theme-based social networks pop up every now and then. They may be based on music (**last.fm**), art (DeviantArt), photography (fotolog), movies (flixster) or even something as absurd as death (Tributes, Respectance, Footnote). Mainly, they'll help you connect with people who are linked by a particular hobby or interest. But a relatively new breed of



Here are a few web sites that will suggest books that you should read based on your likes, dislikes and more:

whatshouldireadnext.com: As the name suggests, the web site will give you suggestions for books you ought to read. From your side, you provide the site with a list of books you like and an exclude list comprising of books you read but didn't quite like. The web site does the rest.

beta.booklamp.org: Unlike socially driven web sites, this one is free of the human element, which might just turn out to be in your favour. BookLamp does an analysis of writing styles by actually analysing a book technically so that users can find books with a similar level of tone, tense, perspective, action, description, and dialogue. At the same time allowing you to suggest parameters such as a book's length.

whichbook.net: The way this site works is completely different from the others listed here. You don't give a list of your books for the site to find similar entries, instead you use sliders to specify certain parameters. The sliders quantify attributes such as funny vs. serious or beautiful vs. disgusting. The sliders will specify how much of a particular element you want in a book. Hit go and you're set.

social networks are emerging that'll go a step beyond and give you recommendations. After its initial faux pas of recommending Britney Spears to The Doors listeners, **Last.fm** has now ironed out the creases and is doing quite well. The same concept is being applied to books by a web site called BookArmy which is actually supposed to recommend new books to you based on your taste. Although a while ago, a web site called Shelfari had tried to implement a similar concept, BookArmy has done it much better. The interface is more user-friendly than Shelfari, and has something to offer to all book enthusiasts, even without registration. As an unregistered user, you can still browse book reviews, look at author bios and watch videos. With a registration you can add

books to your virtual shelf, read and write reviews and get book suggestions. The suggestions, however, leave a lot to be desired. A recommendation for similar books to Metroland by Julian Barnes – a humorous coming of age story set in London returned books by Terry Pratchett which are about elves, magic and sorcery. Hopefully, these are just teething troubles and the site will improve.

Avid book readers would like another service that has a better recommendation algorithm in place called **librarything.com**. It allows similar features such as adding books to your catalogue, rating them and getting recommendations based on them. A unique tool it features is 'Will You Like It' that calculates whether you will like a book based on the books in your library and user libraries similar to you.

Can Google hear me?

While looking at book recommendation platforms, we came across this unique little web site

called **cangooglehearme.com** in connection with one of the book web sites. Curiosity and a little bit of reading revealed that this particular web site is the result of one germ of an idea and a great deal of creativity on the part of one Mr. Aaron Stanton. He believed that he had an idea that could be the next big thing and was just perfect for the internet megalith Google to take up. An idea can get you only so far; how does a small time games reviewer go about getting the attention of a multi-billion dollar giant? He decided to just walk into Google's Mountain View office and speak to someone – he didn't even have an idea who that someone might be. As expected, he was shooed away, but Stanton didn't lose hope. He did the smart thing of video recording his misadventures and putting them up on his web site – **cangooglehearme.com**. He hoped that if he created enough buzz, at least someone at Google

